Alienation through Liberation

Freedom, the State, and the Alienated Individual

Introduction

Patrick Deneen's *Why Liberalism Failed* opens with a paradox: "Liberalism has failed—not because it fell short, but because it was true to itself. It has failed because it has succeeded."[1] The pathologies he catalogs, among them the fraying of families and local communities, the concentration of power in the state and the market, and the isolation of individuals freed from every unchosen bond, are on this account not departures from the liberal project but its fulfillment. Deneen traces them to two foundational assumptions: "1) anthropological individualism and the voluntarist conception of choice, and 2) human separation from and opposition to nature."[2] This essay concerns the first. It argues that Deneen's critique turns on a distinction he draws but does not develop, between liberty understood as the absence of constraint and freedom understood as purposive activity within a whole one recognizes as one's own. Liberalism secures the first and expects the second to follow. Deneen's argument, pressed further than he presses it, is that securing the first destroys the conditions of the second, producing the condition the young Hegel diagnosed in the Roman Empire, in which the state appears to its members as an alien power and their activity serves no purpose beyond themselves. The first part of the essay reconstructs the distinction. The second reads Deneen's account of the liberal state

[1] Patrick J. Deneen, *Why Liberalism Failed* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2018), 3.

[2] Deneen, 31.

alongside Hegel's account of Rome. The third turns to what Deneen leaves undeveloped, the alienation of activity itself, and the conclusion uses the mature Hegel to test Deneen's remedy.

I. Liberty and Freedom

The distinction this essay depends on is one that liberalism's founders deliberately erased. "LIBERTY, or FREEDOME," Hobbes wrote, "signifieth (properly) the absence of Opposition,"[3] and he drew the political consequence at once: the liberty of a subject lies "only in those things, which in regulating their actions, the Soveraign hath praetermitted," that is, in the silence of the law.[4] On this view the two words name one thing, and that thing is negative: the space in which no one prevents me from acting as I choose. Deneen's description of liberal liberty is recognizably Hobbes's. It is "the condition in which one can act freely within the sphere unconstrained by positive law."[5]

Against this Deneen sets an older conception. For the classical and Christian traditions, *libertas* was "the learned capacity of human beings to conquer the slavish pursuit of base and hedonistic desires": self-government, in the soul and in the city, achieved through virtue and sustained by the habits and institutions that form it.[6] Liberty in this sense is a discipline rather than an absence, and it requires the dense social world that liberal liberty treats as a set of obstacles. Benjamin Constant had drawn a related contrast in 1819, between the liberty of the ancients, which consisted in active participation in collective self-government, and the liberty of the moderns, which consists in the secure enjoyment of private independence.[7] Constant preferred the modern kind, but he warned that its danger lay in citizens becoming so absorbed in private enjoyment and the pursuit of their particular interests that they would surrender their share of political power too easily. Deneen's book can be read as the claim that Constant's warning came true.

[3] Thomas Hobbes, *Leviathan*, ed. Noel Malcolm (1651; Oxford: Clarendon Press, 2012), chap. 21.

[4] Hobbes, chap. 21.

[5] Deneen, *Why Liberalism Failed*, 37–38.

[6] Deneen, 37.

[7] Benjamin Constant, "The Liberty of the Ancients Compared with That of the Moderns," in *Political Writings*, ed. and trans. Biancamaria Fontana (1819; Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988), 307–328.

Neither Deneen nor Constant, however, states the distinction in the form the argument needs. What liberal liberty leaves out is not only self-mastery or participation but freedom in the sense Hegel placed at the center of his philosophy: the condition of an agent who acts within institutions and purposes she recognizes as her own, so that in serving them she realizes herself rather than submitting to something external. On this conception, which this essay calls freedom as distinct from liberty, activity is free when it is directed toward a common end and when the social world in which it takes place is experienced as the work of those who live in it. Liberalism's wager is that if individuals are given liberty, freedom will take care of itself. Each will pursue his own conception of the good, and whatever purposes people share will emerge from their voluntary agreement.

Deneen's objection is that the wager defeats itself. Liberal liberty is achieved by freeing individuals from unchosen bonds: the place they were born, the family and faith they inherited, the customs of their community. But those bonds were the medium in which freedom in the fuller sense was possible. Following Wendell Berry, Deneen describes community as "a rich and varied set of personal relationships, a complex of practices and traditions drawn from a store of common memory and tradition, and a set of bonds forged between a people and a place that—because of this situatedness—is not portable, mobile, fungible, or transferable."[8] A community "lives and acts by the common virtues of trust, goodwill, forbearance, self-restraint, compassion, and forgiveness."[9] In such a setting an individual's activity can have a purpose beyond himself, because there is a whole, concrete and particular, for it to serve. Remove the setting and the activity remains, but its purpose contracts to the individual who performs it.

II. The State as an Alien Institution: Hegel's Rome and Deneen's Modernity

The liberal story holds that the individual and the state are natural antagonists, and that freedom grows as the state is restrained. Deneen argues that the relationship runs the other way:

[8] Deneen, *Why Liberalism Failed*, 78.
[9] Deneen, 78–79.

> Far from there being an inherent conflict between the individual and the state—as so much of modern political reporting would suggest—liberalism establishes a deep and profound connection: its ideal of liberty can be realized only through a powerful state. If the expansion of freedom is secured by law, then the opposite also holds true in practice: increasing freedom requires the expansion of law. The state does not merely serve as a referee between contesting individuals; in securing our capacity to engage in productive activities, especially commerce, it establishes a condition in reality that existed in theory only in the state of nature: the ever-increasing achievement of the autonomous individual.[10]

The argument has a lineage, and recognizing it strengthens rather than weakens it. Tocqueville warned that democratic individualism, the disposition to withdraw from public life into a small circle of family and friends, would leave citizens isolated and therefore dependent on "an immense tutelary power" that would provide for their needs and relieve them of the trouble of governing themselves.[11] A century later Robert Nisbet argued that the centralized modern state and the atomized individual had grown up together, each at the expense of the intermediate associations of family, guild, church, and locality that once stood between them.[12] Deneen's contribution is to locate the cause of this double movement in liberalism's founding conception of the self. If the individual is by nature unencumbered, then every inherited bond is a constraint to be removed, and the only agency powerful enough to remove them is the state. As communities weaken, individuals turn to the state and the market for the care, security, and identity that communities once provided, and the state's expanded role weakens communities further.

The consequence is that the state, which liberal theory presents as the creation of its citizens' consent, comes to be experienced as something else. Citizens view it, in Deneen's words, "as an entity separate from their own will and control, not their creature and creation as promised by liberal philosophy."[13] The young Hegel had a precise name for this experience. In "The Positivity of the Christian Religion," written in 1795–96, he called an institution *positive* when it confronts people as something given from outside and imposed by au-

[10] Deneen, *Why Liberalism Failed*, 49.
[11] Alexis de Tocqueville, *Democracy in America*, ed. and trans. Harvey C. Mansfield and Delba Winthrop (1835–40; Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2000), 663.
[12] Robert A. Nisbet, *The Quest for Community* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1953).
[13] Deneen, *Why Liberalism Failed*, 7.

thority, rather than as the expression of their own reason and will.[14] His central historical case was the passage from the Greek city to the Roman Empire. The Greek citizen, as Raymond Plant summarizes the ideal Hegel shared with many of his German contemporaries, lived in a world where "social practices and institutions such as religion, morality and politics were all closely interwoven," so that "the individual citizen was able to develop a roundedness and wholeness to his personality by being able personally to take part in all these interwoven social activities."[15] Rome dissolved this unity:

> The picture of the state as a product of his own energies disappeared from the citizen's soul. The care and oversight of the whole rested on the soul of one man or a few.... The administration of the state machine was entrusted to a small number of citizens, and these served only as single cogs deriving their worth solely from their connection with others.... Usefulness to the state was the great end which the state set before its subjects, and the end they set before themselves in their political life was gain, self-maintenance, and perhaps vanity. All activity and every purpose now had a bearing on something individual; activity was no longer for the sake of a whole or an ideal.... Freedom to obey self-given laws, to follow self-chosen leaders in peacetime and self-chosen generals in war, to carry out plans in whose formulation one had had one's share—all this vanished. All political freedom vanished also; the citizen's right gave him only a right to the security of that property which now filled his entire world.[16]

The parallel with Deneen is close. In both accounts, a political order that no longer appears as the work of its members leaves them with a right to security and property and nothing to do with their freedom but pursue private ends. Hegel's Roman citizen and Deneen's liberated individual share a condition: they are protected but not free, secure in a world whose whole they neither shape nor serve. The freedom Hegel says vanished, moreover, is not the ethical self-mastery Deneen emphasizes but the participatory self-legislation of Constant's ancients, freedom "to obey self-given laws." Hegel's case suggests that Deneen's argument needs the second at least as much as the first.

[14] G. W. F. Hegel, "The Positivity of the Christian Religion," in *Early Theological Writings*, trans. T. M. Knox, with an introduction by Richard Kroner, Written 1795–1796 (1948; Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1996).

[15] Raymond Plant, "Hegel and Political Economy (Part I)," *New Left Review*, nos. I/103 (1977), https://newleftreview.org/issues/i103/articles/raymond-plant-hegel-and-political-economy-part-i.

[16] Hegel, "The Positivity of the Christian Religion," 156–157.

Hegel drew a further conclusion from Rome that bears directly on Deneen, and it complicates his argument. The loss of political freedom, Hegel argued, drove the human spirit to seek the absolute outside the world. A citizen who could no longer find the whole in his city looked for it in a transcendent God, which is why Christianity in the Roman world took the positive, other-worldly form it did; the objectivity of the deity, in Hegel's account, grew in step with the corruption and servitude of human beings.[17] Religious life, on this view, was not the cure for political alienation but one of its forms. The conclusion returns to this point.

III. The Alienation of Activity

Deneen describes in detail the alienation of the individual from community and from the state. What he leaves undeveloped is the alienation of activity itself, the estrangement of a person from what she spends her life doing. This is the dimension the young Hegel's account implies and the young Marx made explicit. In the manuscripts of 1844 Marx characterized human beings by their capacity for "free, conscious activity": the capacity to produce not merely to satisfy immediate need but according to purposes we set, in ways that shape a common world.[18] Alienated labor, for Marx, is activity reduced to a means of individual survival, performed for another and directed toward ends the worker does not choose.

Deneen's account supplies the social conditions of this estrangement even where it does not name it. The liberated individual, disembedded from the bonds that gave his activity a purpose beyond himself, retains only the purposes of gain and self-maintenance that Hegel found in Rome. His work is not a contribution to a whole he recognizes but a means of securing his private existence, and so it appears to him as ineffectual, however productive it may be in aggregate. The setting in which most people now spend that activity is the one Elizabeth Anderson describes as private government, the subject of an earlier paper. This is the deepest sense in which liberal liberation alienates: it secures the individual's liberty to act while depriving his action of any purpose he could recognize as more than his own.

[17] Hegel, "The Positivity of the Christian Religion," ??

[18] Karl Marx, "Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844," in *The Marx-Engels Reader*, 2nd ed., ed. Robert C. Tucker, Written 1844 (New York: W. W. Norton, 1978), ??

Conclusion: Hegel against Deneen

The mature Hegel accepted the young Hegel's diagnosis and rejected the conclusion Deneen draws from it. In the *Philosophy of Right*, Hegel argued that the modern world had introduced a principle the ancient city could not accommodate: the right of subjective freedom, the right of individuals to find satisfaction in their own particular lives, choices, and consciences. Plato's *Republic* failed, on his account, precisely because it excluded this principle,[19] and the strength of the modern state lies in its capacity to let subjectivity develop fully while bringing it back to a substantive unity.[20] A return to the polis was neither possible nor desirable. The task was to mediate between the individual and the whole through intermediate institutions, the family and, within civil society, the professional associations Hegel called corporations and described as the second ethical root of the state,[21] so that individuals could find universal purpose without surrendering their particularity. Plant's article traces exactly this movement in Hegel's thought, from the Hellenic ideal of the early writings to an acceptance of modern civil society shaped by his reading of political economy.[22]

This is the test Deneen's remedy must pass. His alternative to liberalism is not a new theory but a turn toward local cultures of practice, household, and place, built from the ground up. The question Hegel poses is whether such communities can reconcile the modern individual's claim to direct her own life with the universal purpose that alienation has destroyed, or whether they restore purpose only by asking her to give that claim up. If the latter, Deneen's remedy is the nostalgia for the polis that Hegel himself outgrew. The Roman passage adds a sharper difficulty. The communities Deneen hopes for are rooted in inherited traditions, religious ones prominent among them, and Hegel's account of Rome suggests that the turn toward transcendent faith was itself a response to the loss of political freedom rather than a remedy for it. Whether the alienation Deneen diagnoses is the price of modern freedom, to be mediated by institutions that preserve it, or proof that modern freedom was a mistake, to be undone, is the question on which his argument finally depends.

[19] G. W. F. Hegel, *Elements of the Philosophy of Right*, ed. Allen W. Wood, trans. H. B. Nisbet (1820; Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1991), §185 Remark.
[20] Hegel, §260.
[21] Hegel, §255.
[22] Plant, "Hegel and Political Economy (Part I)."

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